

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 7, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Labor Day kicks off election push

The fall campaign season starts in Illinois with distractions becoming a leading theme

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Labor Day marks the unofficial yet traditional launch of the fall general election campaign, and for the major candidates it also means a shift in focus from downstate fairs, tours and rallies to the vote-rich Chicago area, where statewide races are typically decided.

While politicians fanned out across the state this weekend for holiday parades and other events, this year's campaigns for governor and U.S. Senate have been notable for the distractions — national politics, internal infighting, cash concerns and future aspirations — that have clouded the candidates' messaging.

Among Chicago voters, there's

also the distraction of a looming mayoral race that has drawn more interest than what many may view as a perfunctory Nov. 3 state election.

All campaigns ultimately come down to a referendum on the candidates, and this general election is no exception.

For Democrat JB Pritzker, that means his tenure in office, as he seeks a rare third term as Illinois' chief executive while potentially seeking a White House bid two years hence. For his Republican

challenger, former state lawmaker Darren Bailey, that means trying to escape the yoke of an unpopular-in-Illinois President Donald Trump, as well as memories of Bailey's nearly 13-percentage-point loss to Pritzker four years ago. Meanwhile, an independent candidacy from little-known former GOP political operative Collin Corbett looms.

In the U.S. Senate race, the battle to succeed retiring Illinois senior Sen. Dick Durbin comes down to Pritzker's two-time former running

mate, Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton, and business owner and ex-state Republican Chair Don Tracy. Stratton has largely treated Tracy as a distraction by ignoring him. Tracy has sought to paint Stratton as part of the Democrats' leftward progressive-socialist wing but has few outside resources to try to deliver his message.

The leading candidates atop the GOP ticket — Tracy, from Springfield, and Bailey, a former state representative and senator from

See **CAMPAIGNS** on Page A2



ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Along for the ride

Thousands of people enjoy the rare opportunity to ride bicycles on DuSable Lake Shore Drive as part of the annual Bike the Drive event on Sunday. A 30-mile stretch from Hyde Park to Edgewater was closed to cars from 6:30 to 11:30 a.m. **Story on Page A2**

New Loop restaurants replacing 2020 losses

Recovery seen years after pandemic drove many out of business

By Brian J. Rogal
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Hundreds of downtown restaurants shut their doors in 2020, and many never reopened. But Rishi Kumar, an owner and culinary director of Mariela, a new restaurant at the corner of Washington and State streets, said he now sees the Loop as a great place to do business.

"Bringing the culinary scene back to life downtown has been a long-time dream," he said.

Kumar and his partners opened Mariela in May, and they're far from alone. Nearly 20 downtown restaurants, cafes and dessert shops opened in the spring, with another 20 opening in the summer or following months, according to a report from the nonprofit Chicago Loop Alliance.

The new businesses include Japan-based Hello Kitty Cafe and other international brands, national chains such as Panda Express and Portillo's, along with European-style cafes run by local entrepreneurs.

See **LOOP** on Page A4



Boaters travel on the Fox River on Aug. 29. The Safe Fox River Coalition cited state records showing 45 boating accidents on the river from 2016 to 2026, with six fatalities. **BRIAN HILL/DAILY HERALD**

Calls for 'common sense' on river

Some residents want speed limit for boaters after fatal high-speed crash on Fox waterway

By Robert McCoppin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Boaters often wave as they pass each other on the water. Jeff Matheson, a boater on the Chain O' Lakes, proposed a modest change in honor of the woman who was struck and killed recently by an allegedly intoxicated boater. Instead of waving, Matheson proposed flashing a

peace sign to signify safer boating.

"Let's make this tragedy mean something and attempt to make change for the future," he wrote on Facebook.

Others have proposed a more concrete change for the Fox River: specifically, a speed limit.

Prosecutors said boater Richard Stevenson, of Lisle, was intoxicated and traveling at about 80 mph in July on the river when

his pontoon hit a boat carrying Magdalena Jablonska of Des Plaines, decapitating her, authorities said.

Stevenson was charged with murder and aggravated driving under the influence, authorities said.

A Change.org petition called for "common sense" regulations like setting a speed limit and possibly engine-size limits for boats on the river, noting the accused boater had three

See **RIVER** on Page A4

Deaths of 2 icons strike chord for feminists

Steinem, Parton embodied contrasting versions of strength

By Laurie Kellman
and Bill Barrow
ASSOCIATED PRESS

One shaped and delivered the language of feminism. The other rejected the label but showed how feminism can be done: with a microphone dusted in rhinestones, and without apology.

Gloria Steinem and Dolly Parton embodied two towering versions of the same idea: that women should know themselves well enough to make their own choices about matters intimate and societal. Their deaths eight days apart sent a double dose of grief around the world and across generations as many asked who would take their places at the forefront of women's rights.

Steinem, overtly political, went undercover as a Playboy bunny to deliver an exposé, founded Ms. Magazine and spent the rest of her life urging women to support each other.

Parton, on the other hand, defined herself as a larger-than-life daughter of the South who told stories with music and included everybody — but refused to play politics or call herself a feminist.

"Dolly taught us to dream big. Gloria taught us to speak up," wrote DeMond B Nason, a New York City singer.

Parton didn't say so, but Steinem insisted more than three decades ago that the pair fit together under the same feminist flag.

"If feminism means each of us finding your unique power, and helping other women do the same, Dolly Parton certainly has done both," Steinem wrote in 1987, when Ms. Magazine named the singer one of its "Women of the Year."

See **FEMINISM** on Page A8

INSIDE

Iran planning 'exclusion zone'

A top security official for Iran said Tehran plans to announce an "exclusion zone" outside the Strait of Hormuz aimed at vessels it believes are attempting to transit the waterway. **Nation & World, B1**

Another milestone for Cubs' PCA

Pete Crow-Armstrong joined elite company in Cubs history when he slugged his 40th home run Sunday to tie the game against the Miami Marlins in the fifth inning. The Cubs lost 10-3. **Sports, C1**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 80 L: 65
TUE. H: 86 L: 73
WED. H: 82 L: 64
FULL WEATHER REPORT A10

INDEX

Almanac A8
Advice B6
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-9
Crossword B9
Editorials A5
Horoscope B8
Nation & World B1
Television B7

179th year No. 250
© Chicago Tribune

